

The plugin handbook

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Every file type in this application is a plugin, and every plugin is one crate with two halves. This handbook is three pages long so the PDF plugin has more than one page of real text to extract.

Page two describes the two halves. Page three lists the rules a new plugin has to follow before its work order can close.

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1. Two halves, one crate

The core half

Linked into the service. It sniffs a bounded prefix, decides whether it recognises the format, and parses the file into structured data. It is the only half that ever sees a raw byte, and it runs under the read limits: no plugin may pull an unbounded file into memory.

The presentation half

Linked into each front end. It turns that structured data into lines, an icon, a picture, an edit surface, or several named views. It never touches the filesystem and never sees the file itself.

Why the split

A front end can be replaced without reimplementing eighty parsers, and parsing stays off the UI thread. The service is the only process that reads or writes the disk, so there is one place to audit.

2. Rules for a new plugin

1. File the work order first. Every changed line traces back to one.
2. State the acceptance checks. They are the definition of done, not the code looking right.
3. Land the behaviour with a test. A parser with no test is a guess.
4. Add a fixture under samples/, and make it exercise every field the plugin extracts. A hello-world proves nothing.
5. Record the format in PLUGINS.md, built or rejected, before anyone proposes it a second time.

What a fixture is for

Two readers: a person checking the application by opening files, and a test suite checking that each file still opens through the plugin that owns it. A fixture too small to distinguish one plugin from another serves neither.